

IES Applicant Assistant — Project Overview & Technical Dossier

An interactive applicant orientation and self-check prototype built for the International Excellence Scholarship (IES).

CANDIDATE / AUTHOR

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SUBMISSION TRACK

IT Skills Challenge — Eligibility & Fit Checker Tool

LIVE VERCEL DEMO

campus-ewe6hdo1b-me-3f2b.vercel.app

TARGET ORGANIZATION

Copernicus Berlin e.V. (Berlin, Germany)

DELIVERABLE DOCUMENT

Arman_Ogannisian_IT_EligibilityTool.pdf

GITHUB REPOSITORY

github.com/Hovhannisyan111/Campus

Project Rationale: Most university exchange brochures read like course catalogs. The International Excellence Scholarship is built on an inspiring blend of study abroad and active community engagement. This prototype was created so applicants can grasp that difference right away and discover how their personal skills fit into real IES project tracks.

1. Why I Built This & The Problem It Solves

When I first researched the International Excellence Scholarship, one detail stood out clearly: community engagement is at the core of the experience. Unlike standard exchange programmes where scholars solely attend university lectures and transfer credits, Copernicus Berlin expects students to collaborate on meaningful projects and contribute their practical skills.

The challenge is that prospective applicants often miss this differentiator. When someone lands on a scholarship website from a social media link or a student group chat, they are usually skimming. If they only see dense institutional text, they might assume it is an ordinary academic exchange—or they might hesitate to apply, thinking they need an exclusively theoretical academic profile.

I built the **IES Applicant Assistant** to bridge that gap. The app walks students through a straightforward, 5-stage discovery path:

- **Discover:** A welcoming hero section that communicates the programme philosophy in plain language within seconds.
- **Explore:** A side-by-side presentation of the three core pillars (Exchange Study, International Community, and Community Engagement) so expectations are clear from day one.
- **Self-Check:** A 4-step questionnaire where students assess their enrollment status, Berlin motivation, teamwork willingness, and practical skill areas.
- **Learn:** Personalized contribution track recommendations paired with an FAQ accordion answering practical questions about Berlin and the application process.
- **Apply:** A prominent, direct link guiding students to the official Copernicus Berlin portal (copernicusberlin.org/en) when they are ready to apply.

2. Key Features of the Prototype

Interactive Fit Checker

A lightweight 4-step questionnaire asking about university enrollment, motivation for studying in Berlin, willingness to volunteer, and technical or creative skills. It suggests concrete contribution tracks (such as Technology & Digital Innovation, Media & Communications, or Social Projects).

Controlled Knowledge Assistant

A proof-of-concept conversational helper strictly bounded by verified Copernicus Berlin documentation. It answers general orientation questions without guessing cycle-specific deadlines or financial aid values, politely referring students to official channels for unverified queries.

Live Funnel Analytics HUD

A developer drawer that monitors user progression in real time, logging events such as questionnaire start, stage completions, and outbound clicks to the official portal. This demonstrates how a production version could gather data to improve applicant conversion.

Explicit Factual Integrity

To protect applicant trust, the prototype deliberately avoids placeholder statistics, invented stipend amounts, or fictional deadlines. Every result screen features a prominent notice clarifying that the tool is strictly for personal guidance and does not decide official eligibility.

3. User Experience & Design Considerations

- **Copernicus Visual Identity:** I adapted the color palette directly from the Copernicus Berlin brand: energetic orange (#F37021) expressing student initiative, paired with deep navy (#1A2A44) for academic reliability, set on a warm cream background (#FDFBF7) that is significantly easier to read than stark white.
- **Mobile-First Usability:** Students predominantly discover opportunities on mobile devices via Instagram, TikTok, or messaging apps. I prioritized touch-friendly targets, fluid layout scaling, and legible typography across all screen widths.
- **Low-Pressure Interaction:** Rather than facing a daunting checklist of formal criteria, applicants answer simple questions one at a time with clear visual progress, keeping cognitive fatigue to a minimum.
- **Clear Orientation Disclaimers:** To avoid any confusion, every recommendation screen displays: *"This tool is for informational guidance only and does not determine official eligibility. Please consult the official IES information before applying."*

4. Technical Quality & Architecture

Layer	Technology	Architectural Rationale
Frontend	React 18 + TypeScript 5.6	Provides strict type safety across questionnaire states, preventing runtime bugs and simplifying long-term maintenance.
Styling	Tailwind CSS 3.4	Configured with branded design tokens for consistent spacing, colors, and responsive breakpoints without bloated stylesheets.
Build Engine	Vite 5.4	Delivers fast hot-module replacement during local testing and produces an optimized production bundle for swift browser loading.
Decoupled Data	src/data/*.ts	All questionnaire logic, track definitions, FAQ entries, and links reside in separate data files. Copernicus staff can modify text or add questions without touching React components.
Event Tracker	src/utils/analytics.ts	A lightweight pub/sub event bus logging funnel metrics to session storage, designed for easy integration with tools like PostHog, Matomo, or GA4 in the future.

5. Submission Package & Review Instructions

To inspect and review this submission for the Copernicus Berlin Skills Challenge:

1. Review this documentation dossier (Arman_Ogannisian_IT_EligibilityTool.pdf) for an overview of the concept and technical setup.
2. Test the live web prototype deployed on Vercel: <https://campus-ewe6hdo1b-me-3f2b.vercel.app/>
3. Inspect the full source code and commit history on GitHub: <https://github.com/Hovhannisyan111/Campus> (also included in the Source_Code/ folder).
4. Inspect the interface captures in the Screenshots/ folder illustrating desktop and mobile views.
5. Access the project materials and live walkthrough video in the dedicated Google Drive folder (shared with **“Anyone with the link can view”** permissions).

6. AI Tool Usage & Authorship Disclosure

In full alignment with Copernicus Berlin's academic integrity principles: I utilized AI developer tools (such as IDE-based code completion) for technical assistance—specifically setting up TypeScript type boilerplate, validating CSS utility classes, and troubleshooting build configurations. All underlying concept development, user experience design, questionnaire scoring logic, brand styling decisions, and written documentation were authored, structured, and reviewed by me.